



ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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TWO-BOUNCER RULE IN IPL HAS TILTED SCALES A LITTLE BIT IN FAVOUR OF BOWLERS

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Cricket's glitziest tournament, the Indian Premier League, started its 17th season with the defending champions, the Chennai Super Kings, winning their first match. It was not as halfway exciting as the first-ever IPL match in 2008 when Brendon McCullum scored an explosive 158, and the Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) won with plenty to spare.

It was just the kind of takeoff that a new tournament needed. Royal Challengers Bangalore (RCB) were on the losing side then, and the 17th season also began with a loss for them. **They will surely take heart from the fact that their women's team won the Women's Premier League (WPL) in only their second season.**

Though it's early days yet, the new rule allowing bowlers to bowl two bouncers in an over has made it just that little bit difficult for the batters. In previous seasons, with the 'one

bouncer in an over' rule, if a bowler bowled a bouncer in the first half of the over, the batsman could safely put his front foot forward for the remainder of the over, knowing that nothing would come around his shoulders.

So, the new rule has certainly tilted the scales a little bit towards the bowler in a format that is incredibly hard for their tribe. If somehow the ground staff can increase the size of the boundaries, say even by a couple of metres, that could mean some of the mishits that go for a six could be caught inside the boundary.

The weather, at least for now, is still not very hot, but as the days go on and we come to mid-April and May, then the heat can be telling on the batsmen as well.

Ever since the Ranji Trophy finished, it became public knowledge as to what the players of both teams that played the finals got for playing all the Ranji Trophy matches. There

has been a lot of talk about the need to increase the remuneration for playing in the country's national championship. With corporate jobs drying up for the players, the Ranji Trophy is the only source of income for those who do not play in the IPL. The Ranji Trophy is also the feeder tournament for those aspiring to play Test cricket for the country. Since those cricket players who make themselves available to play most of the Test matches are now going to be rewarded with double or triple their fees, it would be terrific if the same yardstick was used for players who played the Ranji Trophy.

One would have expected the current superstars of Indian cricket to raise their voices and ask for an increase in Ranji Trophy remuneration for their Ranji teammates. Sadly, since the IPL began, apart from Harbhajan Singh, who played the Ranji Trophy after he finished playing international cricket, nobody has spoken about